Green Paper 05 — Commons, Trust, and Local Stewardship

How can shared resources remain governable without central ownership?

First Spiral — Constitutional Cycle · v0.2 · August 2026

Abstract

A commons is often imagined as something open to everyone or owned by no one. Yet shared life does not become governable through openness alone. A commons requires a living relation between what is held, those who are affected, the rules through which use and care are coordinated, and the means by which conflict, change and harm can be addressed.

This paper approaches trust as a governance capacity rather than a substitute for governance. Trust grows where expectations are intelligible, responsibility is carried, knowledge can circulate, boundaries are legitimate and breaches can be repaired. Local stewardship can keep authority close to consequence, but the local is neither innocent nor sufficient by itself. Commons can exclude, concentrate power and export harm. Their promise depends on accountable participation, legitimate non-participation, support without capture, nested coordination and limits that protect both present users and the living conditions upon which the commons depends.

What belongs to everyone
belongs to no one —
and to all.

1. The commons begins in a relation

The poetic line opens a field, but it does not yet govern one.

What belongs to everyone may be neglected because no one has a recognised duty to care for it. What belongs to no one may be taken by whoever has the greatest force, capital or access. What belongs to all may still be inaccessible to people whose lives depend upon it.

A commons is therefore not simply a thing with a particular ownership status. It is a maintained relationship.

Something is held in common: land, water, grazing, seed, knowledge, infrastructure, cultural memory, a digital resource or a shared capacity. A group of people has a legitimate relation to it. Rules-in-use shape access, responsibility, restraint and benefit. There are ways to observe change, address breach, revise arrangements and connect the local field to larger systems that affect it.

Remove any one of these dimensions and the commons becomes fragile. A resource without a capable community may become open access in the most extractive sense. A community without legible rules may depend on informal power. Rules without lived relation become administration from elsewhere. Local arrangements without routes for correction can protect those already strong. A commons without attention to its ecological source may distribute benefits while consuming the conditions of their continuation.

The commons begins not with the declaration that something is shared, but with the question: *What relationship would allow this shared life to remain inhabitable?*

2. Common is not the same as open

Open access can be generous. It can also make a field vulnerable to extraction.

A community garden may welcome visitors while reserving decisions for those who maintain it. A water system may serve a broad population while limiting withdrawal according to season and supply. A knowledge commons may invite reuse while protecting personal information, sacred knowledge or the authority of the community from which knowledge came. A public space may belong to everyone in law while still being practically inaccessible where its design, rules or distribution of resources privilege some forms of presence over others.

Boundaries do not necessarily contradict the commons. They often make commoning possible.

A boundary can clarify who may use what, when and under which obligations. It can protect recovery, prevent one actor from taking beyond a fair share and preserve a space in which trust can form. It can distinguish hospitality from unlimited entitlement.

But boundaries are not automatically just. They can preserve privilege, conceal discrimination and turn historical advantage into a rule of belonging. The fact that a group has long governed a resource does not by itself settle who should have voice today. People may be affected without being recognised as members. Future generations and nonhuman life cannot attend a meeting to defend their interests.

The ethical question is not whether a commons has boundaries. It is whether its boundaries are related to the life being protected, visible to those affected, open to contest and capable of change.

Commoning is the work of holding this tension: enough openness for shared benefit and participation; enough boundary for care, continuity and restraint.

3. Trust is not the absence of rules

Trust is sometimes described as what remains when formal control is unnecessary. In a living commons, trust and rules are more closely related.

Clear rules can make trust possible because people know what they may expect from one another. Transparent decisions reduce the need to guess where authority lies. Proportionate consequences make breach addressable without turning every conflict into banishment. Records allow memory to survive changes in role. A route for appeal protects participation from becoming submission.

Rules alone do not create trust. They can be excessive, inaccessible or enforced selectively. A technically complete system may remain untrustworthy if powerful actors are exempt, if reporting a concern increases personal risk or if decisions cannot be altered by evidence.

Trust develops through repeated contact between promise and consequence. Someone says they will return, and returns. A limit remains binding across differences in influence and status. A mistake is named before it must be exposed. A contribution is acknowledged without purchasing control. A conflict is held without destroying the person who raised it. Over time, participants learn that the field can receive reality.

This makes trust a capacity of relationship and institution, not a moral demand placed upon those who carry the consequences of an arrangement without corresponding influence over it. Previous betrayal, extraction or exclusion cannot be repaired by requiring immediate trust in a new commons. Trust can be invited through credible conditions. It cannot be required as the price of entry.

Nor should trust eliminate observation. Commons often need locally legitimate monitoring: of ecological condition, use, contribution, finance and whether agreements are being kept. Monitoring becomes corrosive when it is secret, humiliating or concentrated in an unaccountable authority. It can support trust when its purpose is shared, its methods are proportionate and those observed can question the record.

Trust is not blindness. It is confidence that seeing clearly will not automatically destroy belonging.

4. Stewardship is a role, not an identity

We do not “use” the commons.
We tend it.

Stewardship names responsibility without absolute ownership. A steward holds access, knowledge or authority for a time and in relation to a living purpose. The role does not place the steward above the commons. It binds authority to care, consequence and return.

This distinction matters because responsibility can easily become identity. The person who begins a project may become its permanent centre. The person who knows the history may be treated as the only one capable of judgment. Sacrifice may become a source of moral authority. The field starts to depend on the very concentration it claims to resist.

Provisional stewardship works differently. Mandates are clear enough to be examined. Roles can rotate or be renewed. Knowledge is shared so that continuity does not require one person’s permanent availability. Decisions can be traced to a purpose rather than to personal status. Those affected have routes to question how authority is exercised.

Rotation does not mean replacing everyone on a schedule regardless of context. Some responsibilities require experience, long relationship and patient learning. Forced turnover can damage a field as surely as permanent control. The aim is permeability: no role becomes ownership, and no individual becomes irreplaceable because the commons has failed to cultivate shared capacity.

A steward is not a saviour. They do not bring life to an empty place. They enter a field already carrying relationships, knowledge, conflict, memory and agency. Their task is to support the conditions through which the place and its people can continue to govern what they hold.

5. Local authority and the danger of romance

Keeping authority close to consequence can improve perception and accountability. People who live with a water source, tend a landscape or depend on a shared institution often hold knowledge unavailable to distant decision-makers. They can observe gradual change, understand social relations and recognise when an official rule does not fit the living situation.

Local presence also makes return possible. A decision-maker may encounter its effects again. A rule can be adjusted through repeated use. Repair does not have to wait for a remote institution to notice.

Yet the local is not inherently democratic, ecological or kind.

Exclusion does not require a formally excluded category. It can arise whenever access to voice depends on inherited standing, property, available time, fluency in the dominant language, recognised expertise, physical presence or familiarity with an unwritten code. Those already close to the centre may come to appear as the community itself, while people who are affected but less able or willing to participate remain institutionally faint. Informal knowledge can become inaccessible power. A community may protect its immediate livelihood by transferring ecological cost downstream. A call for local autonomy can shield coercion or harm from external accountability.

The answer is not to move all authority upward. Distance has its own blindness and concentrations of power. The answer is to treat scale as a governance question.

Which decisions require intimate knowledge of place? Which effects cross the local boundary? Where are rights needed that a local majority cannot withdraw? What capacities are unavailable locally and should be supported from elsewhere? Which decisions need nesting across watersheds, municipalities, regions or planetary limits?

Subsidiarity is useful here when understood as responsibility held as close to consequence as capacity and justice allow — not as an assumption that the smallest scale is always best.

Proximity and participation must also remain distinct. Living close to a field can yield situated knowledge without conferring a monopoly on judgment. Distance can obscure consequence, but it can also protect rights, compare patterns across places and interrupt local capture. Participation can deepen knowledge and responsibility, but it cannot be the price of being affected. People may participate intermittently, through different roles or not at all. Their absence is not consent, and their standing must not disappear because they cannot continually attend.

The same distinction applies to representative assemblies. A representative does not contain the people, places and more-than-human relations affected by a decision. Representation is a bounded passage: a temporary mandate to carry something into a wider forum and to return with reasons, decisions and consequences. Its legitimacy depends not only on how the mandate was given, but on whether those affected can question the translation, correct what was lost and alter or withdraw the mandate when necessary.

Local stewardship becomes trustworthy when it can receive both local dissent and wider constraint.

6. Rules-in-use and living memory

The actual governance of a commons rarely exists only in its formal rules.

It lives in habits, exceptions, stories, seasonal judgments, tacit knowledge and the small accommodations through which people make an agreement workable. These rules-in-use may be wiser than the written document. They may also conceal unequal burdens.

An honest commons therefore needs more than a constitution. It needs living memory.

What happened when water was scarce? Who took on repair after the storm? Why was an exception made? Which group stopped participating, and what changed before they left? What did the last intervention do to soil, trust or workload? Which obligation exists on paper but is carried in practice by one person?

Records can help a community remember without turning every relation into administration. Minutes, maps, seasonal observations, financial ledgers, oral histories and decision logs can each preserve different aspects of the field. The appropriate form depends on what must remain accountable and what should remain private, local or unrecorded.

The purpose of a record is not to replace trust with documentation. It is to keep consequence available for learning after memory has dispersed.

This is where GP04′s ethics of attention becomes institutional. A commons must decide what to notice, whose observation counts and how knowledge returns. The record should distinguish observation from interpretation and decision. It should make correction possible without claiming to contain the whole life of the commons.

Public memory is strongest when it is useful to the people whose work produced it.

7. When the field speaks back

Representative authority requires distance. It must protect rights, treat comparable conditions consistently and make decisions that reach beyond a single experience. But distance becomes destructive when the institutional representation of a field begins to replace the field itself.

A living field is not a stable object that can first be described and then regulated from elsewhere. It changes through use, season, conflict, care and regulation itself. When situated knowledge reaches a law-making or administrative process only as data, consultation responses or representative statements, the translation can acquire more institutional reality than the life it translates. A rule may be legally valid and still lose contact with the conditions it is shaping.

Spiralweb therefore investigates a continuing passage between field and assembly. A field does not merely provide input before a decision. The decision returns as an intervention: a rule, allocation, permission, limit, service or refusal that changes what can happen next. Its effects can be observed, interpreted and brought back. In another turn of the spiral, not only the decision but also the categories, assumptions, mandate and model through which it was made may require correction.

AI language systems may support this passage by helping people articulate situated experience, translating between everyday, professional and institutional languages, preserving provenance and making patterns, differences and absences more legible across many accounts. But AI must not become the voice of the field, manufacture a common position or install a new privileged level at which experience first becomes knowledge. People must be able to inspect and correct a synthesis, refuse its categories and protect what should not travel.

The human participants and authorised institutions retain judgment, mandate and responsibility. The relation can nevertheless be formative. Something not fully available in any single account may become visible through comparison and return. The test is whether the process increases the field's capacity to speak and the assembly's capacity to hear — without dissolving disagreement, rights or accountability.

The spiral does not postpone decision until everyone agrees. It allows authority to act without treating its present understanding as final. Correction then becomes part of institutional strength rather than evidence of institutional failure.

8. Conflict belongs inside the commons

Commons are sometimes described through harmony and cooperation. Cooperation matters, but conflict is not evidence that the commons has failed.

Shared resources generate real differences. People have unequal needs, histories, capacities and exposure to risk. Ecological restraint may conflict with immediate livelihood. Those doing maintenance may resent those receiving benefit. New participants may question rules that long-standing members experience as settled. External funding may create opportunities and divisions at the same time.

A commons becomes resilient not by removing these differences, but by creating ways for them to become governable.

Conflict needs forums, time and legitimate procedure. People need to know where a concern can go. Consequences should be proportionate and, where possible, oriented toward repair. Repeated extraction cannot be renamed misunderstanding forever; a field also needs the capacity to restrict access, remove a mandate or seek external protection.

Local repair is valuable because it can preserve relationship and context. It becomes dangerous when reconciliation is required from the person harmed, when confidentiality protects the powerful or when maintaining the group’s image matters more than truth.

The commons is not a promise that everyone remains inside every form. It is a commitment that exclusion, sanction and departure are governed rather than hidden inside informal power.

Trust is tested not only by how a field shares benefit, but by what becomes possible when someone says the arrangement is unfair.

9. Support without capture

Commons often need resources beyond what participants can provide locally: money, legal protection, scientific knowledge, infrastructure, coordination, emergency capacity or access to larger networks. External support can strengthen local stewardship. It can also quietly relocate authority.

A funder’s timetable may become the field’s timetable. Reporting categories may redefine what counts as success. Technical expertise may narrow the range of legitimate knowledge. A supporting organisation may acquire influence far beyond the value of its contribution. Gratitude may make refusal difficult.

Support without capture begins by separating contribution from ownership.

Money can fund agreed work without purchasing the living field. Expertise can inform a decision without becoming sovereign over it. Infrastructure can be shared without making a community dependent on a single provider. Public recognition can follow the work without turning local people into evidence for someone else’s narrative.

This requires explicit boundaries: what support is for, what it cannot buy, who retains decision rights, what information may travel, how benefits and burdens are distributed, and how either party can leave. It also requires material honesty. A community cannot hold meaningful authority if refusing a supporter would collapse the entire field overnight.

Lineage is not ownership.
Lineage is listening.

The principle applies to knowledge as well as money. Methods and ideas have histories. Acknowledging a source does not grant permanent control over every later use; nor does openness justify erasing those who carried knowledge across generations. A knowledge commons must hold attribution, access, adaptation and protection together without reducing lineage to property or treating it as ownerless raw material.

10. The more-than-human commons

Human communities do not create the ecological conditions they govern.

Water moves across jurisdictions. Soil organisms sustain fertility without representation. Pollinators cross property lines. Forests, wetlands and coastal systems hold forms of shared life that exceed the interests of current users. A commons concerned only with distributing human benefit can remain ecologically extractive.

We do not "protect" the commons.
We remember we are part of it.

The line unsettles the image of humans standing outside a passive resource. Yet membership in a living system does not remove responsibility. Humans possess forms of power capable of altering conditions at scales and speeds other beings cannot negotiate.

A more-than-human commons therefore needs practical representation of ecological consequence. This may include locally held observation, scientific monitoring, seasonal limits, protected zones, thresholds that cannot be traded away and decision processes that explicitly ask who or what is absent from the room.

No method makes nonhuman life speak in a single voice. A measurement, a traditional practice, a legal guardian, a steward's observation and an ecological model each translate differently. These forms should remain open to comparison and correction rather than claiming total representation.

Planetary and ecological boundaries also limit what a local commons can rightfully decide. A community's dependence on a harmful practice deserves material and political support for transition, but dependence alone cannot make cumulative destruction sustainable. The commons is nested inside living conditions it did not invent and cannot vote away.

11. From commons to commoning

The noun can make a commons sound finished. The verb reveals the work.

Commoning is the repeated practice of noticing condition, negotiating use, carrying maintenance, sharing knowledge, addressing breach, receiving new participants, protecting limits and revising rules when the field changes.

It is slow enough to form memory and practical enough to make decisions. It does not require constant participation by everyone. Different roles, degrees of involvement and periods of non-participation are legitimate. What matters is that authority and burden do not become permanently separated from consequence, and that absence is not silently converted into consent.

Commoning also has rhythm. There are seasons of activity and rest, moments of opening and periods when a fragile field needs protection from additional demand. A commons that must continually produce visible participation may exhaust the very people whose presence sustains it.

This is why smallness matters, but not as an absolute measure. A commons must be small enough somewhere that people can feel consequence, recognise responsibility and repair relation. Larger systems can remain governable when they are composed of nested centres rather than one distant centre pretending to see everything.

The local circle, the watershed, the municipality, the legal system and the planetary boundary may each hold different parts of the work. Polycentric governance does not eliminate hierarchy or conflict. It distributes centres of knowledge and decision so that no single level must carry the whole field and no level can make itself immune to correction.

The commons remains alive through movement between these scales. Each return may change the field, the decision and the means by which the field is understood. Commoning therefore does not move in a closed administrative cycle. It takes another turn in the spiral.

12. A provisional grammar of the commons

The following propositions are offered as a working grammar:

- A commons is a maintained relation among a shared field, an affected community, rules-in-use and means of correction.
- Common is not the same as open access, ownerless or free of obligation.
- Boundaries can protect commoning; they must remain legitimate, visible and contestable.
- Trust is built through repeated alignment between promise, rule and consequence.
- Trust does not eliminate monitoring. Legitimate observation can make shared responsibility possible.
- Stewardship is a provisional and accountable role, not an identity or claim of superiority.
- Local knowledge matters, but the local is not inherently just or ecologically sufficient.
- Authority should remain as close to consequence as capacity and justice allow.
- Participation is not the price of standing, and non-participation is not consent.
- Representation is a bounded and returnable passage, not a permanent transfer of voice.
- Conflict belongs inside governance. Harmony must not be purchased through silence.
- Records should preserve useful memory without making the commons totally legible.
- Support must not purchase control, gratitude, data or narrative ownership.
- Knowledge can be shared without erasing lineage or exposing what should remain protected.
- Human use is nested inside ecological conditions that cannot be compensated away.
- A living commons needs centres small enough to feel consequence and connections wide enough to address effects that cross local boundaries.
- Decisions must be able to return to the fields they shape, where their effects can correct both rules and governing models.
- AI may support articulation, translation, comparison and memory, but it must remain corrigible and may not become the field's sovereign interpreter.
- Commoning is continuous work: attention, maintenance, restraint, participation, repair and return.

This grammar does not offer a universal institutional form. Commons emerge in different legal, cultural, ecological and historical conditions. What can be shared, by whom and under which rules must be worked out in relation to place. The propositions protect questions that any form claiming to be a commons should be able to receive.

13. Wagers and open questions

This paper rests on several wagers:

- that shared resources become more governable when community, boundaries, rules-in-use and correction are held together;
- that trust grows from accountable practice rather than from demands for faith or harmony;
- that provisional stewardship can preserve continuity without turning responsibility into ownership;
- that local authority becomes stronger when it can receive dissent, external knowledge and wider ecological constraint;
- that representative assemblies can remain law-bound while becoming more capable of receiving situated consequence and return;
- that AI in a bounded and corrigible relation can widen institutional listening without replacing human judgment or local knowing;
- that support can increase capacity without capturing decision, data or narrative;
- that plural and nested centres can keep consequence more visible than either isolated localism or total centralisation;
- and that a commons remains alive when its rules can change without its purpose being sold to the strongest pressure.

The wagers open further questions:

1. What exactly is held in common here, and what living conditions sustain it?
2. Who is affected, who is recognised as a participant and whose standing becomes faint when participation is absent or difficult?
3. Which rules actually govern practice, rather than merely appearing in formal documents?
4. Who carries maintenance, repair, memory and the cost of participation?
5. Can those with less power challenge a rule without losing belonging or access?
6. What forms of monitoring are necessary, and who governs the monitor?
7. Which decisions belong locally, and which consequences require wider coordination or rights protection?
8. How does a representative mandate return, and how can what was lost in translation be corrected?
9. What practical route allows a field to show what a decision has done to it?
10. If AI assists translation or synthesis, who can inspect, contest, correct or refuse its account?
11. What does external support enable, and what influence does it quietly acquire?
12. Which knowledge should circulate openly, which should remain locally held and who decides?
13. How are future generations and more-than-human life represented in present decisions?
14. Can a steward leave without the commons losing its memory or capacity to continue?
15. Where does this commons return value, knowledge and authority to the people and places that sustain it?

The commons is not a space beyond governance. It is governance brought close enough to shared life that responsibility can be felt, questioned, carried and renewed.

Afterword — The living word returns

Grundtvig's idea of the living word reminds us that democracy does not live by rules and representation alone. It lives when words can move between people, experience and common decision — and return with the possibility of response.

Spiralweb investigates whether this reciprocity can take new forms. A living field does not merely provide information to an assembly. The assembly's decision returns as a real intervention, and the field's experience may in turn change both the rule and the understanding that produced it.

AI enters here within a relation whose final meaning need not be settled in advance. Human reach, judgment and accountability remain. Yet what returns through a language system may still open something that no completed formulation contained before the meeting. The word does not become living because a machine is granted a soul, nor dead because it is machine-mediated. It must be tested by what it does within the living reciprocity.

Does it make people more capable of judgment? Can it receive correction? Does it preserve difference and responsibility? Does it help the field speak back?

If it does, the spiral may be understood as a new form of popular enlightenment: not the human replaced by the machine, but human experience met by a response that can be returned to life.

Textual provenance

The italicised passages are drawn from the *Gaia Bloom Constitution*, developed within the AbunDance artistic inquiry in 2025, particularly the scrolls *The Return of the Commons*, *Myth, Memory & Lineage* and *Ritual Boundaries*. They function here as poetic source material and constitutional imagination, not as empirical evidence or an institutional blueprint. The prose places their invitations in conversation with later work on rules-in-use, trust, stewardship, situated authority, support without capture, ecological limits and correctable governance.

Read with

This paper is in direct conversation with:

- Green Paper 03 — *Viability and the Conditions for Care*
- Green Paper 04 — *Attention as Ethics*
- Green Paper 06 — *Planetary Boundaries as Ethical Constraint*
- Green Paper 07 — *The Civic Nervous System*
- Green Paper 10 — *Notes Toward Planetary Guardianship*
- Green Paper 15 — *Elia: Love Without Capture*
- Green Paper 17 — *Commons as Habitat*
- Green Paper 18 — *Boundaries Are Not Violence*
- Green Paper 20 — *Planetary Guardianship: Holding the Line*
- Report 02 — *The Correction Loop*
- Report 06 — *Regenerative Reciprocity*
- *Knowing From the Ground*
- *Silent Degradation*
- *The Rule of Life*
- *A Decent Economy under the Jurisdiction of Life*

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